an eclectic prayer-alcove in my home, where dozens of pictures, idols and relics of Hindu deities—including a print that reproduces one of my parents' religious pictures, that I saw my father pray before every day as I grew up—all compete for my reverential attention daily.

Still, the passion of other worshippers keeps drawing me back to temples, especially in my constituency, Thiruvananthapuram, which is blessed with more places of worship per square kilometre than any other metropolis in India, and where friends, colleagues and party workers insist on accompanying me, praying for me and promising assorted divinities that I will perform certain rituals in fulfilment of their undertakings. (I have, as a result, been weighed against bananas, coconuts and salt because *they* had sworn that I would be: this is a powerful incentive against weight-loss, since the heavier I was, the more the temples in question benefited from donations of those items). But I am not complaining. I find peace in the temples, and a strengthening of my ties to those who have accompanied me there, as if we have shared something indefinable in that common space where hope and need combine in supplication to the Divine.

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Some have seen in Hinduism a selfish religion, a collection of individuals praying for themselves, with no equivalent of the Muslim Friday prayer or the Sunday Christian Mass with its service and sermon uniting a community in worship. Philosophically, after all, the most important claim the *Upanishad*s make is that the essence of each individual is also the essence of all things; the human self, the *atman*, and the cosmic reality, Brahman, are essentially the same. This leads to the view that one only needs to look within to find divinity; one has no need of fellow worshippers or collective sermonising. Hindu religious practice is essentially contemplative, as the seeker turns his gaze inwards in quest of real awareness. The *Mundaka Upanishad* (II.2.3)[16] offers a marvellous metaphor: the Imperishable is the target for the seeker, the *Upanishad*s are his bow, constant meditation is his arrow, and the string of the bow is drawn with his mind filled with Brahman. Because of this interiority, some Hindu critics see Hinduism as lacking the unity that strengthens other faiths and helps them to negotiate the modern world